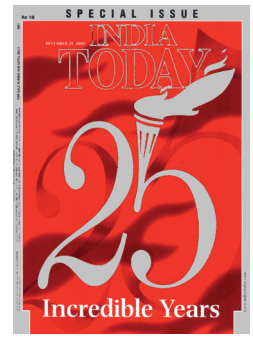
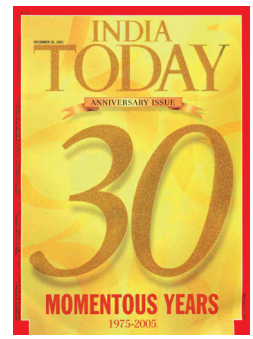
address some of the most universal aspects of life; and architecture, especially when seen through the lens of sustainability, creates the physical world we inhabit. From the general to the more specific, think of business persons and how their genius and worldview impact us. J.R.D. Tata, for instance, cannot be understood without doffing our hats at the creative ways he has given to society with the institutions—and even a city—that he has built. The glorious attainments of the world of sport, again, spring from the level of the individual athlete or player to create a sense of collective joy. From Milkha Singh in 1960 to Kapil's Devils in 1983 to Neeraj Chopra in 2020, they have all crafted truly national moments.

In the arts and culture world, we had to make a difficult categorial omission—especially with cinema and television. How do we talk of the best films without, inevitably, invoking a Ray or an Adoor? How do we account for the vastness of regional cinema or television, with the millions of subjective opinions it evokes? Here, we decided to restrict our choice to Hindi cinema purely because it is the one that is the most travelled one on the map and the one that most Indians enjoy. Then we further subdivided it into its constituent parts—thus, we have separate lists for the best films, directors, actors, actresses, songs and film albums. Similarly, with TV, universality is the criterion.

But the richness of the vast non-Hindi parts of the Indian universe filters through in other realms. In literature, for instance, we scan not only Indian writing in English and the best novels in Hindi but also take a substantial look at regional literature. Art is its own language, of course. The masters of the canvas are duly represented. As are the best plays, regardless of language, and



December 25, 2000



December 26, 2005



January 4, 2021



January 3, 2022

the finest of the classical dancers and musicians who have ennobled our cultural lives.

Selections are bound to be subjective, and we did not wish for our opinions to cloud the act of choosing. Therefore, to select the best, we invited the best. We enlisted domain experts in each category who could adjudicate on their fields with unquestionable authority. Thus, we have eminences like Raghunath Mashelkar, Rajmohan Gandhi, Ashok Gulati, Gita Piramal, T.C.A. Raghavan and Lt Gen. Deependra Singh Hooda gracing these pages. Sunita Narain, India's foremost name in environmental studies, crafts savants Laila Tyabji and Jaya Jaitly, sociologist Amita Baviskar, architect Habeeb Khan, writers Jerry Pinto and Alok Rai, anthropologist G.N. Devy, art curator Giles Tillotson, dance historian Ashish Mohan Khokar, legal scholar Gautam Bhatia, TV producer Amit Khanna, and illustrious names from the world of cinema and writing associated with it—like Varun Grover, Nasreen Munni Kabir, Khalid Mohamed, Rajeev Masand—and many others bring their unique insights into this edition. "Impossible" is a word that kept recurring as a motif in their introductory passages as they set about to make a shortlist of the "best" and the inevitable omissions assailed them. But what each of these 34 experts has given us, and you, the reader, is collectively nothing short of an almanac of our nation. A few others curate the best of Indian experiences, whether in travel, food or hospitality.

We dedicate this issue with gratitude to those who have made this great nation what it is.



(Aroon Purie)